ScopeGuard: Business Recommendation

1. Executive Summary

Recommendation: Validate ScopeGuard with a small group of freelance web designers and developers before investing in a full product.

ScopeGuard is a lightweight tool that compares incoming client requests against agreed project deliverables. It classifies requests as *Likely Included*, *Potentially Out of Scope*, or *Needs Clarification*, explains the relevant scope clause, estimates possible additional effort, and drafts a professional client response.

The prototype demonstrates the core workflow using a local, rule-based heuristic. The next priority should be customer validation, not adding more features.

2. Customer Problem and Opportunity

Freelancers often receive requests framed as “small changes” that can expand the original project. Unclear deliverables and informal communication make it difficult to decide whether to accommodate a request, charge extra, or renegotiate the timeline.

Upwork’s guide to scope creep discusses unclear expectations and weak change-management processes as common contributors to this problem.

Initial target segment: Independent freelance web designers and developers managing fixed-price website projects. This is a focused starting point, not a claim that all freelancers share the same need.

Proposed value: Help freelancers make more consistent scope decisions and communicate them professionally without manually searching through contracts every time.

3. Solution and Competitive Positioning

The MVP focuses on one workflow:

1. Enter the agreed project scope and exclusions.
2. Paste a new client request.
3. Review the classification and matching scope clause.
4. Check the estimated extra effort and cost, where applicable.
5. Edit and copy a suggested client response.

Alternative	Existing strength	ScopeGuard opportunity
Bonsai	Proposals, contracts, invoicing and freelancer workflows	Focus on interpreting new requests against agreed scope
HoneyBook	Client management, contracts, invoices and automations	Offer a narrower scope-checking workflow

Manual documents and messaging	Free and familiar	Reduce repetitive comparison and response drafting

These alternatives already support broader freelancer workflows. ScopeGuard's proposed differentiation is its focused request-to-scope decision process; this advantage still needs validation.

Current prototype: Built with React, Vite, JavaScript and CSS. It uses a local simulated heuristic, not a live AI model or external API. Its classifications and cost estimates are illustrative and require human review.

4. Pricing Hypothesis

Test an initial **₹499/month individual plan** after users have experienced the workflow. This is a pricing hypothesis, not a validated market price.

Before charging, test whether freelancers encounter this problem often enough to pay for a dedicated tool. A free trial or limited free tier could reduce adoption friction.

5. First Five Users and Acquisition

The goal is to recruit five relevant freelancers for feedback, not to claim five customers.

- **Find prospects:** Use freelancer communities, LinkedIn and relevant professional networks.
- **Show the value:** Share the Instagram promotional creative and a short product demo.
- **Start conversations:** Send the prepared outreach message to relevant prospects, where permitted.
- **Observe usage:** Ask participants to test a realistic client request using the prototype.
- **Collect feedback:** Record confusing classifications, missing features, trust concerns and willingness to pay.

Measure responses and completed tests separately. No customer interviews, sign-ups or conversions are claimed at this stage.

6. Hypothetical ₹10,000 Validation Budget

Activity	Budget
Creative refinement	₹1,000
Prospect research and outreach	₹1,000
User feedback incentives, if permitted	₹3,000
Prototype fixes and testing	₹3,000
Contingency reserve	₹2,000
Total	**₹10,000**

These are proposed allocations, not actual spending. Use free tools and direct outreach first; release the optional incentive budget only if necessary and permitted.

7. Risks and Mitigation

- **Incorrect classification:** Show the matching clause and let users make the final decision.
- **Weak differentiation:** Validate whether a dedicated scope-checking tool solves a problem existing platforms do not adequately address for the target segment.
- **Infrequent usage:** Test how often users receive potentially out-of-scope requests.
- **Privacy concerns:** Avoid real confidential contracts during early testing; use sample or anonymised project data.
- **Inaccurate estimates:** Label effort and cost as estimates, not quotations or contractual advice.

8. Thirty-Day Validation Plan

Period	Action
Days 1–7	Recruit five target users and demonstrate the prototype
Days 8–14	Observe task completion and collect structured feedback
Days 15–21	Fix the most common usability and classification issues
Days 22–30	Retest and assess repeated need and willingness to pay

Proposed decision criteria: Continue if at least three of five participants describe the problem as recurring, three can complete the workflow with minimal assistance, and two express credible willingness to try a paid plan or paid pilot. These are proposed thresholds, not achieved results.

9. Final Recommendation

Proceed with a small validation experiment before expanding ScopeGuard. The prototype establishes technical feasibility for a basic workflow, but customer demand, classification accuracy and willingness to pay remain unproven. The next investment should depend on observed user behaviour and feedback rather than additional features alone.